

Chapter 15: Written Assignment

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I agree with the judge's decision for the bronze doors for the Florence Baptistery. Cause if I was a judge at the Florence Baptistery Competition for the East Doors, I would have also chosen Lorenzo Ghiberti over Filippo Brunelleschi. At the time, in 1401 the guild of the cloth finishers and merchants in foreign cloth known as the Arte di Calimala hosted the Florence Baptistery Competition as the 7 known artists competed to decorate the East Doors. Each artists competitor competed by making quatrefoil relief of the scene known as "The Sacrifice of Isaac" from the book of Genesis. The artists needed to fill the four lobes of the quatrefoil and at the same time they needed to express the narrative clearly and naturalistically.

The Competition narrowed down the artists to two finalists, one was a young and unknown sculptor, Lorenzo Ghiberti and other was the more established Filippo Brunelleschi. The trial relief for Brunelleschi was more focused on portraying the emotions and drama of Isaac struggling as his father grabs his neck, holding a knife that is lifted and ready to strike Isaac but is grasped by an angel in the left with the ram standing next to the altar. While the subsidiary figures fill the lower portions of the quatrefoil. While on the other hand the trial relief for Ghiberti has the ram on the mountain in the upper left and the foreshortened angel on the right. While the main characters of the piece were placed at the center. Ghiberti's piece was less menacing, showing the same scene of Abraham lifting his knife dramatically and Isaac seemly look like he does not struggle laying bound and naked on an altar. But seemly heroic in accepting his fate as an angel comes down on the right to stop Abraham.

Both pieces were dramatic and well done, but the major deciding point as a judge and maybe as a member of the guild of the cloth would have been the costs since both works portrayed the scene skillfully. Lorenzo Ghiberti was the son of a goldsmith and trained with goldsmiths, making him a more skilled metalworker compared to Filippo Brunelleschi. As the winning artist would be required to make 28 pieces of quatrefoil relief for the door, which in the end would costing a sizeable amount of bronze. Cause at the time period, bronze was considerably expensive material, costing about ten times the cost of marble, so Ghiberti's technical finesse in metalworking and saving costs made him the more practical choice for commission.